Mahatma Gandhi University, Kottayam-

Third Semester MGU-UGP – BSW (Honours) Regular Examination October 2025

Discipline Specific Elective(DSE)-MG3DSESWK200-**Poverty, Inequality and Social Welfare**

QP Code: **25900634**

Part A Very Short Answer Questions Answer all questions / each question carries 1 marks

1.	State one difference between demand and supply *Demand* refers to the quantity of a good or service consumers are willing and able to buy, while *supply* refers to the quantity producers are willing and able to offer for sale	[K]/[CO1] 1 mark
2.	Describe how the institutional approach addresses welfare as a normal function of society. The *institutional approach* views welfare as a **normal and integral function of society**, emphasizing that social services are rights of all citizens, not just charity for the poor.	[U]/[CO2] 1 mark
3.	List a factor causing racial poverty. *Discrimination in employment and education* is a major factor leading to racial poverty.	[K]/[CO3] 1 mark
4.	Apply the hybrid model to show how welfare principles can combine elements of different systems. The *hybrid model* combines elements of **residual (state support when family/market fail)** and **institutional (universal welfare rights)** systems—ensuring both targeted aid and universal services	[A]/[CO6] 1 mark
5.	Describe how a developmental approach strengthens long-term welfare. The *developmental approach* focuses on **empowerment, capacity building, and economic participation**, which reduce dependency and strengthen long-term social welfare.	[K]/[CO2] 1 mark
6.	Recall the World Bank's current daily income threshold for absolute poverty. As of 2025, the World Bank defines *absolute poverty* as living on **less than $2.15 per day** (in 2017 PPP terms).	[K]/[CO3] 1 mark
7.	Identify one government entitlement accessed with social worker help. Examples include **Public Distribution System (PDS) rations**, **MGNREGA employment**, or **old-age pensions**.	[K]/[CO7] 1 mark
8.	Explain what often happens to local industries under colonial rule. Under colonial rule, **local industries declined** due to exploitation, cheap imports from the colonizer, and loss of traditional markets.	[U]/[CO3] 1 mark
9.	Illustrate how demographic changes affect pension sustainability. An **aging population** increases the number of retirees, putting pressure on pension systems as fewer workers support more beneficiaries.	[A]/[CO6] 1 mark
10.	Identify one social category influencing poverty. *Gender* is a key social category influencing poverty—women often face lower wages, limited access to property, and unpaid labor burdens.	[K]/[CO3] 1 mark

Part B- Short Answer Questions Answer 5 questions / each question carries 3 marks

11.	Illustrate how the MGNREGP strengthens livelihood security in rural India. ➢ **Employment guarantee:** Provides 100 days of paid manual work per year to rural households, ensuring minimum income security. ➢ **Asset creation:** Builds rural infrastructure such as roads, ponds, and irrigation facilities, enhancing long-term productivity. ➢ **Empowerment and inclusion:** Promotes women's participation and reduces distress migration by offering local employment.	[A]/[CO7] 3 marks
12.	Analyze how poor infrastructure creates a geographical poverty trap. 1. **Limited market access:** Poor roads and transport isolate rural producers from markets, lowering income opportunities. 2. **Low investment:** Inadequate electricity, water, and communication deter industries and services from investing in such areas. 3. **Restricted human capital development:** Poor schools and healthcare reinforce low productivity and persistent poverty.	[An]/[CO3] 3 marks
13.	Show with examples how welfare economics influenced poverty alleviation strategies. 1. **Focus on redistribution:** Inspired policies like progressive taxation and social transfers to reduce inequality. 2. **Public goods provision:** Led to government investment in education, health, and sanitation to improve social welfare. 3. **Social justice principle:** Influenced welfare schemes such as PDS, Mid-Day Meal, and healthcare programs for equitable outcomes.	[A]/[CO6] 3 marks

14.	Identify key features of traditional economic systems. ➢ **Subsistence production:** Focus on meeting local and family needs rather than profit-making. ➢ **Custom-based exchange:** Economic roles and trade governed by traditions, norms, and bartering. ➢ **Limited technological change:** Slow adoption of innovation and dependence on natural resources.	[U]/[CO1] 3 marks
15.	Illustrate with examples how universal safety nets operate in society. ➢ **Inclusive coverage:** Benefits provided to all citizens regardless of income (e.g., universal healthcare or education). ➢ **Risk protection:** Shields individuals from economic shocks—like unemployment insurance or pensions. ➢ **Social solidarity:** Examples include schemes like *Ayushman Bharat* (India) or *Social Security* (USA) ensuring collective welfare.	[A]/[CO6] 3 marks
16.	Evaluate the usefulness of the Palma Ratio compared to other inequality measures in assessing income distribution. ➢ **Focus on extremes:** Compares the income share of the top 10% to the bottom 40%, highlighting inequality more clearly. ➢ **Policy relevance:** Easier for policymakers to target redistribution toward the poorest groups. ➢ **Improvement over Gini:** More intuitive and less sensitive to middle-income changes than the Gini coefficient.	[E]/[CO3] 3 marks
17.	Explain how infrastructure development supports growth. ➢ **Increased productivity:** Roads, power, and digital networks enhance efficiency in production and trade. ➢ **Employment generation:** Infrastructure projects create jobs and stimulate local economies. ➢ **Investment attraction:** Reliable infrastructure encourages private and foreign investments, fostering long-term growth.	[U]/[CO2] 3 marks

Part C- Short Essay- Answer 3 questions / each question carries 5 marks

18.	Illustrate how social development reduces inequality. 1. **Access to education:** Improves skills and employment opportunities for marginalized groups, reducing income gaps. 2. **Health and welfare services:** Ensures equal access to healthcare, lowering life expectancy disparities. 3. **Gender equality initiatives:** Promotes women's empowerment and participation in economic and political life. 4. **Inclusive policies:** Encourages social justice through affirmative action and targeted welfare programs. 5. **Community participation:** Strengthens local decision-making and equitable resource distribution.	[A]/[CO2] 5 marks
19.	Explain how Indigenous resistance movements impact development projects. 1. **Protection of land rights:** Challenges displacement and exploitation caused by industrial or infrastructure projects. 2. **Cultural preservation:** Ensures traditional practices, sacred sites, and identities are respected. 3. **Environmental conservation:** Promotes sustainable resource use and opposes ecological degradation. 4. **Policy reform:** Pressures governments to adopt participatory and rights-based development approaches. 5. **Conflict and negotiation:** May delay or reshape projects, leading to more inclusive and ethical development planning.	[A]/[CO5] 5 marks
20.	Demonstrate with examples how growth models can be critiqued a. **Neglect of inequality:** Models like Rostow's stages emphasize GDP growth but ignore social disparities. b. **Environmental concerns:** Growth-centric models overlook sustainability, as seen in industrialization-driven pollution. c. **Cultural bias:** Western models may not suit local contexts (e.g., dependency theory critique of modernization). d. **Overreliance on markets:** Neoliberal models assume trickle-down benefits that rarely reach the poor. e. **Alternative perspectives:** Human Development Index (HDI) and Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) focus on wellbeing, not just growth.	[A]/[CO2] 5 marks
21.	Analyze the limitations of categorizing the poor into "good"and "bad" groups. 1. **Moral judgment:** Labels blame individuals instead of addressing structural causes of poverty. 2. **Policy bias:** "Deserving poor" may receive aid while others are unfairly excluded. 3. **Stigma and discrimination:** Reinforces stereotypes and social exclusion. 4. **Simplification of complex realities:** Poverty is multidimensional and cannot be reduced to	[An]/[CO7] 5 marks

	behavior alone. 5. **Undermines social solidarity:** Divides communities and weakens collective action for justice.	
22.	Discuss the interaction between health and economic poverty traps. a. **Poor health reduces productivity:** Illness limits ability to work and earn income. b. **High medical costs:** Out-of-pocket expenses push families deeper into poverty. c. **Malnutrition and low education:** Weak health affects learning and long-term earning capacity. d. **Limited healthcare access:** Rural and poor populations lack affordable medical services. e. **Cycle of deprivation:** Poor health causes poverty, and poverty worsens health—creating a self-reinforcing trap.	[E]/[CO3] 5 marks

Part D- Essay- Answer 2 questions / each question carries 15 marks

23.	Apply the concepts of supply and demand to the labour market 1. **Labour supply:** Represents the number of people willing and able to work at different wage levels. 2. **Labour demand:** Reflects employers' need for workers based on productivity and business conditions. 3. **Wage determination:** The *equilibrium wage* is set where labour supply equals labour demand. 4. **Skill differences:** High-skilled workers are in shorter supply, often earning higher wages. 5. **Unemployment impact:** When supply exceeds demand, unemployment rises and wages may fall. 6. **Government intervention:** Minimum wage laws or labour regulations influence wage equilibrium. 7. **Globalization effects:** Outsourcing and migration can shift labour supply and demand across countries.	[A]/[CO1] 15 marks
24.	Evaluate the overall role of the residual perspective in shaping state responsibility for welfare. 1. **Minimal state intervention:** The state provides welfare only when family and market systems fail. 2. **Conditional support:** Assistance is viewed as temporary, targeting only those in dire need. 3. **Emphasis on self-reliance:** Encourages individuals to depend on work and family, not government aid. 4. **Policy influence:** Leads to selective and means-tested welfare programs (e.g., food subsidies, unemployment aid). 5. **Stigmatization of beneficiaries:** Recipients may be viewed as dependent or undeserving. 6. **Crisis response model:** Welfare expands during economic downturns and retracts in stable times. 7. **Critique:** Critics argue it weakens social rights and ignores structural inequalities that cause poverty.	[E]/[CO6] 15 marks
25.	Analyze how media and advocacy reshape attitudes toward trans persons. 1. **Visibility and representation:** Positive portrayals in media increase public awareness and acceptance. 2. **Challenging stereotypes:** Advocacy campaigns counter myths and misconceptions about trans identities. 3. **Policy influence:** Media-driven movements push for legal protections and anti-discrimination laws. 4. **Empowerment narratives:** Highlight success stories and lived experiences of trans people. 5. **Public education:** Social media and documentaries foster understanding of gender diversity. 6. **Backlash and misinformation:** Sensationalized or biased coverage can also reinforce prejudice. 7. **Cultural shift:** Continuous advocacy promotes normalization of trans identities within mainstream discourse.	[An]/[CO3] 15 marks
26.	Apply strategies to reduce new inequalities caused by climate risk, disasters, and conflicts 1. **Inclusive climate policies:** Ensure vulnerable groups (women, poor, indigenous) are prioritized in adaptation plans. 2. **Social protection schemes:** Expand safety nets like insurance, cash transfers, and food aid during crises. 3. **Sustainable livelihood programs:** Promote climate-resilient agriculture and green jobs. 4. **Disaster preparedness:** Strengthen early warning systems and community-based disaster management. 5. **Peace building and conflict resolution:** Address resource-based tensions and displacement. 6. **Access to technology and finance:** Support marginalized groups in adopting sustainable practices. 7. **Global cooperation:** Encourage equitable climate funding and international aid for developing nations.	[A]/[CO7] 15 marks